Abdul A. Marohombsar

Atty. Abdul A. Marohombsar was an eminent Maranao trial lawyer, jurist, and statesman from Lanao del Sur, Philippines. He is widely recognized for his trailblazing contributions to regional governance and national electoral administration, having served as the Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur, an Assemblyman for the regional legislative body (*Batasan Pampook*) of Region XII, and a national Commissioner of the Commission on Elections (COMELEC).

He was married to **Dr. Hadja Sittie Nurlayla "Emily" Marohombsar (https://wiki.maranaw.com/index.php/Hadja_Sittie_Nurlaylah_%22Emily%22_Marohombsar)**, the **first Muslim female president of the Mindanao State University (MSU) System**. Standing as a foundational pillar of modern Maranao leadership, Marohombsar's career was defined by a strict adherence to judicial integrity, local administrative reform, and ethical modesty.

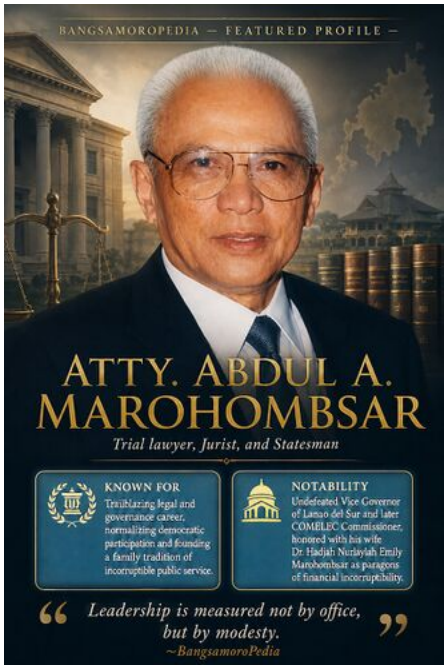
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Early life and familial ties

Abdul A. Marohombsar was born into an influential and noble Maranao clan in the undivided province of Lanao. His family possessed a strong tradition of military and civil leadership. The legendary patriarch **Col. Louis Marohombsar**—a Bataan Death March survivor and the first post-WWII military governor of undivided Lanao, was his father-in-law. Abdul grew up heavily immersed in the complexities of tribal dynamics, civic responsibilities, and regional public leadership, which later defined his approach to law. He was married to his paternal cousin, Dr. Hadja Sittie Nurlayla "Emily" Marohombsar, making Col. Luis Marohombsar both his biological uncle and his father-in-law.

Atty. Abdul A. Marohombsar



Ethnicity

Maranao

Home Province

Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Occupation

Trial Lawyer, Jurist, Statesman

Notable Positions

Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur; Assemblyman, Batasan Pampook (Region XII); Commissioner, Commission on Elections (COMELEC)

Spouse

Dr. Hadja Sittie Nurlayla "Emily" Marohombsar

Children

Abdul Marohombsar Jr., Shainulla Marohombsar, Samerah Marohombsar, Alamina Marohombsar, Ahmad Marohombsar

Notability

Undefeated Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur and later a national COMELEC Commissioner, celebrated together with his wife Dr. Emily Marohombsar as paragons of financial incorruptibility in Bangsamoro public service

Known For

Trailblazing legal career and regional governance leadership that helped normalize democratic participation among

Education and legal career

Marohombsar pursued higher education with a focus on law and governance. He obtained his Bachelor of Laws degree and successfully passed the Philippine Bar Examination, qualifying him as a trial lawyer. His formal legal education equipped him with a profound understanding of constitutional and statutory frameworks, enabling him to bridge the gap between national statutory laws and the traditional socio-cultural structures (*adat*) inherent to the Muslim populations of Mindanao.

the Maranao people, and for founding a multi-generational family tradition of public service across ARMM and COMELEC

Pull Quote

"True leadership is measured not by the offices one holds, but by the modesty one keeps."

Before transitioning into regional and national politics, Marohombsar built an exceptional reputation as a formidable trial lawyer in the Lanao region. He was highly regarded for his litigation skills, legal intellect, and ethical courtroom demeanor. He frequently handled volatile and sensitive disputes, earning the trust of both the local Maranao royalty and national judicial institutions.

Political and public service career

Local and regional governance

Marohombsar eventually entered provincial politics, where he achieved the unique status of being an undefeated Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur. Serving alongside key regional executives, his tenure focused on maintaining institutional peace, introducing bureaucratic reforms, and fostering civic development during eras marked by political shifts and local conflicts.

As the Philippine government attempted to institute regional autonomy structures in the late 1970s and 1980s, Marohombsar was elected as an Assemblyman for the *Batasan Pampook* (Regional Legislative Assembly) of Autonomous Region XII. In this legislative capacity, he helped draft and sponsor regional resolutions that aimed to address the economic, educational, and legal needs of Muslim Mindanao.

COMELEC Commissionership

Recognizing his stellar legal background and unassailable integrity, Marohombsar was appointed by the President of the Philippines as a national Commissioner of the Commission on Elections (COMELEC). As a COMELEC commissioner, he was tasked with overseeing the enforcement and administration of all election laws throughout the archipelago. His presence on the commission was vital in ensuring equitable democratic representation and managing complex electoral exercises in historically conflict-prone areas of Western and Central Mindanao.

Personal life and incorruptibility

Marohombsar was married to **Dr. Hadja Sittie Nurlayla "Emily" Marohombsar**, a fellow Maranao intellectual who went on to become an iconic figure in Philippine academia. Dr. Emily Marohombsar was a pioneering faculty member of the Mindanao State University (MSU) Main Campus in Marawi when it opened in 1961. She steadily rose through the academic ranks to become a Dean, Vice President, and ultimately the 4th President of the MSU System, securing her place in history as the university's first female and first Muslim head.

Despite holding some of the highest, most influential offices in regional and national governance, Atty. Marohombsar and his wife were celebrated for their extraordinary honesty and financial incorruptibility. Observers and relatives frequently noted that the couple never utilized their offices for personal enrichment. They lived out their retirement decades modestly, choosing to reside in a standard government-provided cottage on the MSU Main Campus in Marawi City rather than amassing luxury vehicles or personal estates.

The marriage was blessed with five children:

- Abdul Marohombsar Jr.
- Shainulla Marohombsar
- Samerah Marohombsar
- Alamina Marohombsar
- Ahmad Marohombsar

Atty. Abdul A. Marohombsar passed away prior to the demise of his wife, who died in May 2013.

Legacy and cultural significance

Atty. Marohombsar's legacy continues to heavily reverberate across Lanao del Sur and the broader Bangsamoro region:

- **The Anti-Graft Standard:** In a political landscape often scrutinized for corruption, Marohombsar and his wife are held up by modern historians and public administration scholars as paragons of absolute integrity. Their choice to live an unblemished, modest life within university housing while commanding national agencies remains an inspirational benchmark for young Moro public servants.
- **Multi-Generational Public Service:** The family tradition of public service established by Atty. Abdul and Dr. Emily Marohombsar was successfully transferred to their children. Their immediate offspring and descendants went on to fill critical roles in state governance, with various family members serving as municipal judges, provincial vice governors, regional assemblymen in the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM), and subsequent COMELEC executives.
- **Socio-Cultural Upliftment:** Through his legal defenses and structural execution of election mechanisms, Marohombsar directly contributed to the normalization of civil democratic participation among the Maranao people, proving that traditional Islamic societies could seamlessly engage with and excel within the wider Philippine constitutional republic.

Reference

- Online deep search, cross-checked and verified (https://tinyurl.com/yeks827z)

See also

- Commission on Elections (Philippines)
- Mindanao State University
- Lanao del Sur
- Maranao people

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